

The Pale Bell's Ballad of Mournthrone

Come close, you ash-stained daughters, Come near, you oath-worn sons; I sing of Mournthrone's broken word And wars that were not done. Let no priest correct my verses— The bell remembers more Than ink that sleeps in sealed-up books Or iron on a door.

In **297 AS**, the Accord began, With banners under rain; The halls grew dark, the pledges cracked, And mercy learned its chain. The **Ashen Vanguard** raised its sign, While Mournthrone cast its shade; A broken accord beneath that gloom, A promise poorly made.

Palewell Abbey watched the coast, Pale-faced against the foam; In **The Pale Coast**, its rebuilt walls Made war where prayers found home. Founded in **244 AS**, It kept the salt wind near; Austere, awake, its narrow eyes Saw every oath as fear.

O, ring the pale bell, ring it low, For victory tastes of ash; The sword may name the vanquished man, But not the hand that paid the price. O, ring the pale bell, ring it low— The dead are slow to sleep; A settled crown is often cast Where buried bargains creep.

In **301 AS**, the Accord was ended, And the **Ashen Vanguard named victor**; So cried the court, so wrote the seals, So sang each paid-up singer. Yet the losing commander withdrew— Not from courage broken through, But because that commander was bribed To do what blades could not do.

I heard it from a shuttered mouth; I swear it was not mine. The wind may have reshaped the words, The dark may have supplied the sign. Still, truth has teeth beneath its tongue, And secrets learn to crawl; A victory built on purchased steps Will stagger when they fall.

Then came a decade of reprisals, Guerrilla fires in rain; The road forgot the king's decree, The fields recalled the slain. From abbey wall to ruined hold, The old wounds opened wide; The Accord lay dead, yet every night Its ghost walked at our side.

So sing, you guards of Palewell, Where sanctuary wears a spear; Your garrison is **5998**, And watchfulness is prayer. Though Palewell Abbey is not a core holding, Its pale stones still endure; A garrison more than sanctuary, With no peace to make it pure.

Remember: Mournthrone shadows all, And broken vows bear flame. The **Ashen Vanguard** may claim the song— The **Ashen Vanguard** may claim the name. But beneath the bell, beneath the ash, Beneath the victor's throne, The Accord of Mournthrone still breathes In every blade drawn alone.